

The Five Types of Agentic AI Systems (And Which Framework Fits Each)

Learn to classify an agentic AI project by its coordination pattern so you can pick a framework instead of guessing from a list of GitHub stars.

For developers evaluating LangChain, CrewAI, AutoGen, or similar tools who need a mental model for which one actually fits their project · 27 July 2026

The one- or two-page version: what matters, the topics it covers, and every term defined. Read the full lesson for the explanations and worked examples.

[Watch the source video](#)[Read the full lesson](#)[Read the condensed version](#)

What matters

- ✓ An agentic framework's core job is coordinating planning, tool calls, and state across steps or agents — work a single LLM call never has to do.
- ✓ The useful question is 'what shape is my system?', not 'which framework is best?' — the five patterns map almost directly onto specific tools.
- ✓ Linear workflows (LangChain, LlamaIndex, LangGraph) suit tasks with a fixed, predictable sequence of steps and no need for agents to negotiate with each other.
- ✓ Autonomous multi-agent systems (AutoGen, CrewAI, BabyAGI) suit open-ended goals where agents work out their own division of labor.
- ✓ Role-based multi-agent systems (CrewAI, structured AutoGen, ChatDev) look like autonomous systems but confine each agent to a fixed role boundary, trading flexibility for predictability.
- ✓ Production orchestration frameworks (Microsoft's Agent Framework, LangGraph) add the deep API and database integration and the reliability a system needs once it leaves experimentation.
- ✓ Rapid prototyping tools (LangFlow, Flowise) trade architectural rigor for a drag-and-drop canvas that validates an idea before you invest in a real build.

What it covers

01 What an Agentic Framework Actually Coordinates 1:24

An agentic framework exists because doing more than one LLM call — planning, tool use, iteration, and often inter-agent communication — needs reusable coordination machinery that a plain chatbot never requires.

02 Linear Workflows 3:30

When steps happen in a fixed, predictable sequence, a linear workflow gives full control and reliability without the overhead of agents negotiating with each other.

03 Autonomous Multi-Agent Systems 4:54

Give the system a goal instead of a procedure, and multiple agents figure out the steps and division of labor between them — the pattern for open-ended problems.

04 Role-Based Multi-Agent Systems 6:23

Multiple agents still collaborate toward a shared goal, but each one operates inside a fixed role description instead of improvising its responsibilities.

05 Production Orchestration Systems 8:34

Once an agent moves out of experimentation and into a real system, it needs deep integration with APIs, databases, and business workflows, plus the reliability a prototype never had to have.

06 **Rapid Prototyping Tools** 9:57

When the goal is just to check whether an idea works at all, a drag-and-drop canvas trades architectural rigor for speed of validation.

Glossary

Agentic AI framework — A toolkit that provides reusable coordination machinery — architectures, task/state management, monitoring, and communication protocols — for building AI systems that plan, act, and iterate rather than answer a single prompt.

Autonomous multi-agent system — A pattern where multiple agents share a goal and work out the steps and division of labor between themselves, suited to open-ended problems.

Production orchestration — A pattern focused on deep integration with live APIs, databases, and business systems, plus the reliability and observability a system needs once it leaves experimentation.

LangChain — A framework for composing sequential chains of prompts, tools, and LLM calls, well suited to linear workflows.

CrewAI — A framework for building multi-agent teams, usable both for open-ended autonomous collaboration and for role-based teams with defined responsibilities.

Agent Framework — Microsoft's merger of Semantic Kernel and AutoGen, aimed at production-grade agent orchestration with deep system integration.

Linear workflow — An agent pattern where steps execute in a fixed, predetermined sequence decided at design time rather than negotiated at runtime.

Role-based multi-agent system — A multi-agent pattern where each agent operates inside a fixed role description rather than improvising its responsibilities, trading flexibility for predictability.

Rapid prototyping tool — A visual, low-code tool for quickly testing whether an agent idea works before committing to a full architecture.

LangGraph — A framework from the LangChain team that models agent workflows as a graph rather than a strict list, letting it handle both structured linear flows and more complex, stateful production orchestration.

AutoGen — A Microsoft framework for building conversable agents that exchange messages with each other to work toward a goal.

Explanations are AI-generated. Check anything you intend to rely on.